I stop at the town of Amravathi, the future capital of Andhra Pradesh. This is also the site of the former capital of the Satavahana Empire, which flourished in the first two centuries CE and served as an early major conduit for the northern Indo-Aryan culture into the south. I visit the excavated remains of the Great Stupa of ancient Amravathi, which once contained the Buddha's relics, and the nearby site museum donning brickwork inspired by the Great Stupa. The Krishna River here is shallow and sluggish. Is the Nagarjuna Sagar Dam upstream not releasing much water? Or perhaps much of its water is being diverted for irrigation and other human needs? I pass places with names like Mandadam, Pedamudduru, Gudipudi, Sattenapalle and Piduguralla. I relish rolling these words around my tongue. All of this land was once part of the Ikshvaku realm, which covered modern Guntur, Krishna and parts of Nellore and Nalgonda districts.

Four hours later, I'm in Vijayapuri South once again, a village of over 10,000 people. But I recognize little of it from my previous visit. As with so many places in India, it too has grown larger, noisier, denser and unevenly prosperous. From here ferries run daily to Nagarjunakonda Island (forty-five minutes each way), including a ferry named Chamtisiri, after a royal woman of ancient Vijayapuri. In the middle of an intersection near the ferry terminal is a shiny golden statue of B.R. Ambedkar in his signature pose: raised right hand pointing forward, with the left clutching a copy of the Indian Constitution. I check into a decaying AP Tourism hotel overlooking the lake. Faded pictures of the ancient site and the dam adorn its lobby and rooms.

Excavation and Submersion

The first archaeologists to visit the ruins of Vijayapuri in the 1920s found the valley 'dotted with numerous rocky hillocks and artificial mounds covered with grass and jungle'. Many limestone pillars were still standing. From 1927–31, Longhurst's team dug up many mounds to reveal 'ruined monasteries, apsidal temples, stupas, inscriptions, coins, relics, pottery, statues and over four hundred magnificent bas-reliefs in the Amravathi style' of the Satavahana Empire.[3]